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# No, AI Art Isn’t Killing the Environment - Here's the Data

Posted by u/story_of_the_beer • • 0 points • 81 comments

Training a major art model once uses roughly the same electricity as about 20 gaming PC non-stop for a year\[[1](https://huggingface.co/blog/carbon-emissions-on-the-hub)\], which now serves millions of people. Generating an image after that typically takes only a few watt-hours on modern hardware, about the same as running a LED light bulb for an hour\[[2](https://arxiv.org/pdf/2506.17016v1)\], so even at millions of images a day it is negligible compared to the energy global data centers burn through\[[3](https://www.iea.org/commentaries/the-carbon-footprint-of-streaming-video-fact-checking-the-headlines)\].

And water usage? Data centers aren't AI factories, they also power social media, banking, streaming and more\[[4](https://sustainability.google/reports/google-2023-environmental-report/)\]. Blaming AI art for that water usage is like blaming one table at a restaurant for the kitchen's water bill\[[5](https://arxiv.org/abs/2304.03271)\] and if you run it locally (which many do), you’re not even in the restaurant.

**If AI is ‘killing the planet’, then your Twitter feed, YouTube playlists, and email inbox have destroyed the entire solar system first.**

**Sources:**
\[1\] [Hugging Face: Carbon Emissions on the Hub](https://huggingface.co/blog/carbon-emissions-on-the-hub) \- Stable Diffusion XL training took \~150,000 GPU-hours on 256 A100 GPUs, roughly 60 MWh of compute energy before cooling/overhead.
\[2\] [Quantifying the Energy Consumption of AI Image Generation](https://arxiv.org/pdf/2506.17016v1) \- Image generation inference is typically in the low single-digit watt-hours per image on modern hardware.
\[3\] [ The carbon footprint of streaming video: fact-checking the headlines](https://www.iea.org/commentaries/the-carbon-footprint-of-streaming-video-fact-checking-the-headlines) \- Global data centres used \~415 TWh in 2024, making large-scale AI image generation a tiny fraction of total usage
\[4\] [Google: Environmental Report 2023](https://sustainability.google/reports/google-2023-environmental-report/) \- Most data center load is from non-AI workloads, a pattern unlikely to have shifted significantly in the past year.
\[5\] [Making AI Less Thirsty](https://arxiv.org/abs/2304.03271) \- \~500 ml water for 10–50

GPT-3 prompts in worst-case scenarios.

## Comments